

PHENOMENOLOGY & CASE STUDY

The goal of this chapter is to describe phenomenology and case study. This chapter focuses first on the meaning of phenomenology, its characteristics, and the principles applied in phenomenological research. The following discussions explain the different models, features, and steps in conducting phenomenological research. This chapter also describes the nature, types, and uses of the case study. The various advantages and disadvantages of the case study are also discussed.

Phenomenology

In qualitative research, phenomenology explores in detail how participants interpret and make sense of their personal or subjective experiences. Phenomenology is the study of human experience based on the individual's perspective. The goal of qualitative phenomenological research is to explain the "lived experience" of a research participant. Because this is a qualitative investigation of narrative data, the methods used to analyze it differ significantly from more traditional or quantitative research methods. The purpose of a phenomenological method is to discover and illuminate specific phenomena based on how the participants in a scenario perceive them. In the human realm, this typically entails acquiring "deep" knowledge and perspectives through inductive, qualitative procedures like interviews, discussions, and participant observation, and expressing it from the perspective of the study's participant.

However, psychologists are mostly responsible for questions regarding more mundane aspects of experience. What happens when research participants say things like "That felt very romantic," "My head feels like exploding, "or" I tried her cooking, and I like it"? Why does one person see a symbol as a sign of safety while another interprets it as a sign of danger? How can some people regard a painting as valuable art while others regard it as worthless trash? In order to answer these problems, psychologists gather empirical evidence. Researchers use phenomenology to gain a better understanding of the structure of people's awareness in a given environment in order to better comprehend the motives and the meaning of different acts related to the goal of survival.

Characteristics of Phenomenological Study

The following are characteristics of phenomenological study:

- Phenomenology focuses on the participant's experiences, not on social or cultural norms, traditions, or preconceived notions about the experience;
- It concentrates on four dimensions of lived experience: lived space, lived body, lived time, and lived human relationships;
- It aims to comprehend how people react to a specific phenomenon;
- It is primarily carried out through in-depth discussions and interviews;
- Data can be gained through diaries, drawings, or observation;
- Phenomenological studies frequently use small sample sizes, with 10 or fewer participants;
- Open-ended interview questions allow participants to fully describe their experience from their own perspective;

- The data collected is qualitative, and analysis includes a search for themes or generalizations about how a phenomenon is actually perceived or experienced.

Principles Applied to Phenomenological Study

- Rather than measurements or explanations, phenomenology looks for the meaning or essence of an experience;
- Researchers should start with *Epoche* practice to describe their own experiences or ideas about the phenomenon in order to become more aware of their underlying emotions;
- Phenomenological research differs from other types of research in that it is frequently participatory, with other participants serving as co-researchers in many cases;
- Rather than focusing on the individual parts of the experience, this type of research focuses on the whole experience;
- Phenomenology differs from other types of research in that it does not test a hypothesis and does not anticipate the results to be predictive or repeatable. Additional research into the same topic frequently reveals fresh and different interpretations;
- The research can be used on a single instance or a carefully chosen sample.

Different Models of Phenomenological Study

Ethnography

Ethnography is the study of people and their cultures in their own surroundings, employing methods like face-to-face interview and participant observation. Ethnography should be able to chronicle cultural similarities and differences through actual fieldwork and produce scientific generalizations of human behavior and social and cultural systems' actions. Ethnography provides detailed descriptions provided by the group or civilization to fully comprehend the people being studied. Ethnographers then look for and collect records on the people's way of life from both the people's and the researcher's perspectives; this might be emic (observing from the inside) or etic (observing from the outside).

Grounded Theory

Grounded Theory (GT) is a research method that focuses on the development of a theory. 'This method is "grounded" in data that had been systematically collected and analyzed to identify social ties and group behavior. Grounded Theory also includes data gathering and analysis, theoretical sampling for category refinement, social processes based on the data collected, analytical memos utilized between writing and coding, and categories that are incorporated into a theoretical framework.

Hermeneutics

According to Hans-Georg Gadamer, hermeneutics is more than just the craft of interpretation. Hermeneutics also provides insight into the central and educational concern of human cognition. The 'art of interpretation,' as it is sometimes referred to, along with conservative, radical, critical, and moderate hermeneutics are the four primary points of view of interpretation. Knowledge of the world's historical context, disciplinary knowledge, and questioning are some of the things that fall into this category. Hermeneutics involves a deep understanding of the context, language, and cultural background of a text to interpret its meaning accurately. It also involves a critical examination of biases and assumptions that may influence the interpretation of a text.

Empirical Phenomenological Research

Empirical phenomenology is an approach to social research that is grounded in the first-order constructions of one's own meanings. Although their philosophical insights can be employed in empirical study, the empirical phenomenology arose from the phenomenology of two philosophers, Edmund Husserl and Martin Heidegger, and sociologist Alfred Schutz.

Heuristic Research

The Heuristic approach is a manner of engaging scientific study through procedures and methods for discovery; it is a form of self-inquiry and discourse that tries to uncover underlying meanings for the significance of human experiences. Meaning and judgment take place deep within the human experience, and perception and beliefs necessitate a passionate and disciplined commitment to passionately and continually question until it is fully answered or illuminated.

Common Features of Phenomenological Research

The following are the four features of phenomenological research:

1. **Description** - The goal of phenomenology is to describe phenomena rather than to explain them. Phenomenology refers to the science of describing something to the "thing itself." Because the goal is to explore as it happens, speculation is no longer necessary.
2. **Reduction** - Reduction is a procedure in which assumptions and preconceptions about a phenomenon are postponed to ensure that biases do not contaminate the description of the observations and that the form of the description is the same as the things themselves.
3. **Essence** - The essence is the core meaning of an individual's unique experiences in a phenomenon. Searching for the essence will reveal the major themes or connections.
4. **Intentionality** - The terms *noesis* and *noema* are used in phenomenology to express intentionality. The subjective reflection (consciousness) of the objective assertion is *noema*, whereas the objective declaration of action or experience as fact is *noesis*. Intentionality refers to the relationship between noema and noesis that guides experience interpretation.

Stages in Conducting Phenomenological Studies

The following are the five stages of the phenomenological process:

1. **Bracketing and phenomenological reduction** - The Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy describes phenomenological reduction as a technique where the phenomenologist puts him or herself in a position to provide adequately rigorous grounds for scientific or any other kind of inquiry. It is a deliberate and purposeful opening by the researcher to the phenomenon "in its own right with its meaning." It also refers to the researcher's presuppositions being suspended or "bracketed out" (or epoche), "in the sense that no position is taken either for or against" and not allowing the researcher's meanings and interpretations or theoretical concepts to enter the unique world of the informant/participant (Creswell & Creswell, 2018).
2. **Delineating Units of Meaning** - This is a crucial stage in the data analysis since it is at this point that the statements that are thought to provide light on the studied phenomena are removed or "separated"(Creswell & Creswell, 2018). To avoid making improper subjective judgments, the researcher must make a significant number of judgment calls while deliberately bracketing her or his presuppositions. In this stage, the list of relevant meaning units retrieved from each interview is thoroughly examined, and any units that are redundant are removed. To do so, the researcher evaluates the content, the number of times a meaning was conveyed, and how it was presented.
3. **Clustering of Units of Meaning to Form Themes** - In this stage, the researcher brackets her or his presuppositions once more with the list of non-redundant units of meaning in hand. The researcher attempts to derive the essence of the meaning of units within the holistic context by thoroughly reviewing the list of units of meaning.
4. **Summarize each interview, validate, and modify**- A comprehensive context is provided by a summary that combines all of the themes evoked by the data. Regardless of the approach utilized for phenomenological analysis, the investigator's goal is to recreate the subject's inner world of experience. The researcher then does a "validity check", returning to the informant to see if the substance of the interview was accurately "captured". As a result of this "validity check", necessary changes are made.
5. **General and unique themes for all the interviews and composite summary** - When all of the interviews have gone through the procedure mentioned in stages 1 through 4, the researcher looks for "themes common to most or all of the interviews as well as individual variances." If there are substantial disparities between the topics, it is important not to group them. The unique or minority viewpoints are crucial counterpoints to the topic under investigation.

Steps in the Descriptive Phenomenological Process

The first step in the descriptive phenomenology process is **intuition**, in which researchers have a thorough understanding of the phenomenon. Researchers who want to understand more about a phenomenon could interview others who have experienced or worked in the field. The researchers avoid criticizing, assessing, or expressing an opinion on things provided by the participants. In this context, researchers instead concentrate on the phenomenon under examination, resulting in a more accurate representation. The researcher serves as a tool in the interview process at this point.

The second stage is **analysis**, in which researchers try to figure out what the phenomenon means and look for similarities and connections between the data and other events. The importance of the data is fully examined. As a result, the researchers have all the data they need to generate a pure and powerful image. The **phenomenological describing phase** is the third step, in which researchers communicate and provide a textual description of the important aspects based on the categorization and grouping phenomenon. The goal of this phase is to explain the meaning and relevance of the participant's experiences.

Case Study

A case study is a research approach that strives for a generalized collection of data from an extensive systematic inquiry that involves reviewing in-depth data pertaining to its factors. It may be described as a study on a person, a group, or units. Researchers are aware that it is a complicated phenomenon that must be studied in a natural context in order to have a better grasp of it. Case studies are holistic and they describe the actions performed. This type of research approach helps researchers take broad or complicated issues and focus them down to a specific study issue(s). There are some data sets that can only be gathered in this manner, allowing for an in-depth analysis of phenomena.

Purpose and Nature of a Case Study

Case study research enables the examination and comprehension of complicated topics by using reports from previous studies. It is a reliable research approach, especially when a comprehensive, in-depth inquiry is necessary. Researchers are growing increasingly worried about the limitations of quantitative approaches in giving comprehensive and in-depth explanations of social and behavioral problems, which led to the acknowledgment of case study as a research technique. A researcher can use case study methodologies to go beyond quantitative statistical data and comprehend behavioral situations from the perspective of the actors. Through full observation, reconstruction, and analysis of the instances under examination, case studies explain both the process and consequence of a phenomena by using both quantitative and qualitative data.

Common Parts of a Case Study

1. **Situation**-the rationale for the case study is described in this section, which includes the client's background.
2. **Problem** - the main problem that needs to be solved is stated in this section.
3. **Solution**-the most important part of the research. It goes into great detail about the solution, how it was implemented, the impact on users, methodologies, and other factors that influenced the overall process. To emphasize key points, many case studies include sidebars, charts, and graphs.
4. **Evaluation**- in the final part, conclude the document by assessing the solution's positive impact, discussing lessons learned, and outlining the next steps.

Advantages of Case Study

There are a number of advantages in using case studies. First, most data analysis is done in the context of its usage, that is, in the context of the activity itself. The researcher must study the subject in his or her setting, such as reading in a classroom or reading for pleasure, to learn about the tactics he or she employs. Second, the application of different intrinsic, instrumental, and collective techniques allow for quantitative and qualitative data analysis. For example, some longitudinal studies of single people depend on qualitative data from journal articles that provide descriptive accounts of behavior. On the other hand, there are a number of case studies that look for evidence from specific participants' numerical and categorical replies. Third, case studies typically yield extensive qualitative narratives that not only aid in investigating or describing data in a real-world setting, but also in explaining the intricacies of real-world circumstances that may not be captured by experimental or survey research. A case study of reading strategies employed by a single

subject, for example, can provide access to not just numerical information on the strategies employed, but also the reasons for their usage and how they relate to other strategies (Yin, 2018).

Disadvantages of Case Study

Case studies are typically criticized as lacking rigor. While citing studies from other studies may be a double-edged sword, "it is apparent that too often, the case study investigator has been careless, and has allowed ambiguous evidence or prejudiced views to affect the direction of the results and conclusions." A second consideration is that case studies give little to no data for scientific generalization due to their use of just a limited number of participants and the use of a single subject in a number of investigations. The third point is that case studies are typically regarded as being overly long, difficult to undertake, and yields large amounts of material (Yin, 2018).

Types and Uses of Case Study

1. **Collective case studies**-These entail the investigation of a large group of people. Researchers may focus on studying a certain group of individuals in a particular location, or they may examine the entire population of individuals.
2. **Descriptive case studies** - Descriptive case studies are conducted based on a descriptive theory. Prior to this, the theory has already been formulated, and the participants are watched and the data acquired is compared to the preexisting hypothesis.
3. **Explanatory Case studies**-These are typically utilized to conduct a causal study. So, to be more specific, researchers are interested in looking at possible causes that may have really caused something to occur.
4. **Exploratory case studies**-An Exploratory Case Study is used to develop an initial understanding of the program or phenomenon of interest. The focus is on discovery for the purpose of obtaining an empirically based introduction to the structure, dynamics and context of the subject of interest. Exploratory case studies are particularly useful for developing hypotheses to be tested, research questions to be answered, and/or design options to be used in a more focused and in-depth subsequent study (Chopard & Przybylski, 2021).
5. **Instrumental case studies**- An instrumental case study is a qualitative research that investigates a specific case to acquire insights into more significant issues or construct hypotheses. Using various data sources, an instrumental case study uses a case to gain insights into a phenomenon. It is recognized for its ability to provide in-depth, multi-faceted explorations of complex issues in real-life settings. For example, a researcher interested in teenage obesity might conduct a study with high school students and an exercise program. In this particular case, the teenagers and the exercise program are not the main focus. The main focus is determining the relationship between teenagers and exercise, and why some teenagers become obese.
6. **Intrinsic case studies** - An intrinsic case study is a qualitative research method used to examine a specific case because it is intrinsically fascinating, unique, or worthy of investigation for a particular reason. According to Robert Stake (Bhatta, 2018), the purpose of intrinsic case study is to understand a particular case not to draw generalization and theory. For example, a psychology teacher conducted a case study on an innovative teaching method in psychological statistics. The case may be intrinsically interesting because it is relevant to the teacher's practice or experience which makes it special and worth investigating. Such cases are described as intrinsic case studies.

Key Points

- Phenomenology is the study of human experience which aims to discover phenomena based on how the participants in a scenario perceive them.
- Models of phenomenological study includes ethnography, grounded research theory, hermeneutics, empirical phenomenological, and heuristic research.
- The four features of phenomenology as a method are descriptive, reduction, essence, and intentionality.
- A case study is a research approach that strives for a generalized collection of data from an extensive systematic inquiry that involves reviewing in-depth data pertaining to its factors.
- Common parts of case studies include situation, problem, solution, and evaluation.
- Case studies may be collective, descriptive, explanatory, exploratory, instrumental, and intrinsic.

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